

Newman - Securus judicat

Securus judicat orbis terrarum — the Apologia narrative and two letters (*Apologia pro Vita Sua*, pp. 116–117; *Letters to Mrs Helbert and to Miss Giberne*)

by John Henry Newman (1801–1890); *Apologia* 1864/65, letters of 20 October 1869 and 15 October 1870

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- Sources: *Apologia pro Vita Sua* (“History of My Religious Opinions”), pp. 116–117 ([scan](#)); *The Letters and Diaries of John Henry Newman*, vol. 24 (1868–1869), pp. 354–356, and vol. 25 (1870–1871), p. 215 ([vol. 25](#)).
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Note on this selection: Newman’s three securus-judicat texts, in ascending explicitness. The Apologia (1864) gives the narrative: Augustine’s words, quoted in Wiseman’s Donatist article of 1839, “struck me with a power which I never had felt from any words before” — because the deliberate judgment of the whole Church is “an infallible prescription and a final sentence against such portions of it as protest and secede.” The letter to Mrs Helbert (20 October 1869 — weeks before the Vatican Council opened) applies the maxim directly to the two questions this repository documents: “How do we know that Pius ix is true Pope? Securus judicat orbis terrarum. How again we know that the coming Council is a true Council — but by the after assent and acceptance of it on the part of the Catholic organization which is lineally descended, as one whole, from the first ages?” — with the remnant-reductio (“if there are two Churches, they cannot both of them be Christ’s Church — which of them is the orbis terrarum?”) and the reception-rule for councils (“I put the validity of the Council upon its reception by the orbis terrarum”). The letter to Miss Giberne (15 October 1870) supplies the definition, numbered like a catechism answer: the maxim means “when all Christians agree together in a judgment,

that is a sure warrant that its judgment is right” — and therefore the Church “need not go back, to Scripture, or antiquity, in proof of a point in dispute, if it is in all its members of one way of judging.” Under the taxonomy of the root *README* Newman is School 1 (the concordant judgment is a “sure warrant” — it cannot be wrong), with no scholastic note assigned: the acceptance-criterion as the very ground of his conversion and of his answer to every “local disturbance” that appeals past the living Church — Donatists, Arians, Monophysites, Protestants, Anglicans — to the Fathers.

Apologia pro Vita Sua, pp. 116–117 — the Donatist article and the palmary words of St. Augustine (1839, narrated 1864)

Hardly had I brought my course of reading to a close, when the *Dublin Review* of that same August was put into my hands, by friends who were more favourable to the cause of Rome than I was myself. There was an article in it on the “Anglican Claim” by Dr. Wiseman. This was about the middle of September. It was on the Donatists, with an application to Anglicanism. I read it, and did not see much in it. The Donatist controversy was known to me for some years, as has appeared already. The case was not parallel to that of the Anglican Church. St. Augustine in Africa wrote against the Donatists in Africa. They were a furious party who made a schism within the African Church, and not beyond its limits. It was a case of Altar against Altar, of two occupants of the same See, as that between the Non-jurors in England and the Established Church; not the case of one Church against another, as of Rome against the Oriental Monophysites. But my friend, an anxiously religious man, now, as then, very dear to me, a Protestant still, pointed out the palmary words of St. Augustine, which were contained in one of the extracts made in the Review, and which had escaped my observation. “*Securus judicat orbis terrarum.*” He repeated these words again and again, and, when he was gone, they kept ringing in my ears. “*Securus judicat orbis terrarum;*” they were words which went beyond the occasion of the Donatists: they applied to that of the Monophysites. They gave a cogency to the Article, which had escaped me at first. They decided ecclesiastical questions on a simpler rule than that of Antiquity; nay, St. Augustine was one of the prime oracles of Antiquity; here then Antiquity was deciding against itself. What a light was hereby thrown upon every controversy in the Church! not that, for the moment, the multitude may not falter in their judgment,—not that, in the Arian hurricane, Sees more than can be numbered did not bend before its fury, and fall off from St. Athanasius,—not that the crowd of Oriental Bishops did not need to be sustained during the contest by the voice and the eye of St. Leo; but that the deliberate judgment, in which the whole Church at length rests and acquiesces, is an infallible prescription and a final sentence against such portions of it as protest and secede. Who can account for the impressions which are made on him? For a mere sentence, the words of St. Augustine, struck me with a power which I never had felt from any words before. To take a familiar instance, they were like the “Turn again Whittington” of the chime; or, to take a more serious one, they were like the “*Tolle, lege,*—*Tolle, lege,*” of the child, which converted St. Augustine himself. “*Securus judicat orbis terrarum!*” By those great words of the ancient Father, interpreting and summing up the long and varied course of ecclesiastical history, the theory of the *Via Media* was absolutely pulverized.

To Mrs Helbert, The Oratory, 20 October 1869 (Letters and Diaries XXIV, pp. 354–356)

TO MRS HELBERT The Oratory Oct 20. 1869

My dear Madam I shall be truly pleased to see you here, as you propose, when you come to Birmingham. I have always great difficulty in giving advice to persons I do not know, but especially by letter. One may do more harm than good.

I do not think you have read aright my remarks in the Apologia, on Dr Wiseman's article on the Donatists. I think I expressly say that it did *not* strike me and I had known it for years. What did strike me was a passage he quoted from St Augustine which contained a maxim going far beyond the purpose of the controversy — Securus judicat orbis terrarum — 'the Christian commonwealth judges without misgiving.'¹ That is the maxim, (as I also feel now,) on which all depends. The Christian commonwealth is one organized body — from time to time local disturbances rise in it — branches of it rise up separately from the rest, and claim to be heard in matters of discipline or doctrine — they appeal to the Fathers — so did the Donatists, so did the Arians, the Monophysites, the Protestants, the Anglicans — but the Christian State, Commonwealth, Kingdom judicat securus, has the right, the power, the certitude of deciding the rights and the wrongs of the matter. How do we know that Pius ix is true Pope? Securus judicat orbis terrarum. How shall we know that the coming Council is a true Council — but by the after assent and acceptance of it on the part of that Catholic organization which is lineally descended, as one whole, from the first ages? — How can we interpret the decisions of that Council, how the Pope's decisions in any age, except by the Schola Theologorum, the great Catholic school of divines dispersed all over the earth? This is why I am a Catholic — because our Lord set up the Church — and that one Church has been in the world ever since — because in every age bodies have fallen off from her, and have shown in the event that that falling off was death — that they tended to lose all definite faith, *as* bodies, (I don't mean *individuals* in them, as Dr Pusey) but as bodies — the Arians came to nought, and the Donatists — and the Greeks show no signs of life, but remain shut up as if in the sepulchre of the past — and now the Anglican Church is gradually losing any definite faith, and is upheld only by the virtue and faith of its individual members. This is one of the great facts by which God meant the learned and unlearned to be guided — not by explorations into history, which are beyond most of us — not by comparison of the state of the Church with the claims of science and the theories and the needs of civil governments. Supposing upon Dr Temple's appointment,¹ Dr Pusey and others broke off from the Church of England, and set up a new communion with a new Episcopal succession, and supposing he (Dr Pusey) still said that he was one body with the Church of England — He might say so, if he would — but would any one believe it — would not every one smile, and say that it was a fiction, an imagination? who will call the Methodists one body with the Church of England? Why then not be honest, and say out, that the Church of England, in a parallel way, broke off from the Roman Communion in the 16th century? why not say out, that the Anglican Church is *not* one body with the Roman Church? Next then, I say, if they are two Churches, they cannot both of them be Christ's Church — which of them is the orbis terrarum — that organized, constituted body of which St Cyprian and St Augustine write?

As to majorities and minorities in the Ecumenical Council, the *final act* of the Council is always unanimous, or the dissentients speak out and leave the Council — as at Nicaea and Sardica. But, as above, I put the validity of the Council upon its reception by the

orbis terrarum, of which Greece and England are no part. Sometimes years have passed before a Council has been generally received — e.g. the Third Council (at Ephesus) nay, the Nicene — and so again the Fifth — and, I may say, the Second.

As to the Archbishop's Sermon, it speaks to Catholics not Protestants — Protestants are sure to take it in the sense which to a Catholic is not conveyed in its words.^{^2} e.g. He makes the Pope say 'I am the sole *last* Supreme Judge of right and wrong —' now look at that little word 'last.' Any Protestant would think it meant that man had no *natural conscience* — but that the Pope *made* right and wrong — which every Catholic knows to be a wicked heresy — but the Archbishop knew what he was saying, and he says no such thing, and any theologian, the high authorities at Rome, will quite understand the theological force of his words. He says 'the sole *last* judge;' that is, to him is the *appeal* when men differ IN DETAIL. Supposing the question was whether the rules about stealing could be modified by the laws of the state, I mean, as to gravity of particular acts, or whether smuggling was always, or in what sense, a bad sin — or poaching — or certain cases of duelling — or whether usury was allowable, or under what circumstances, and Catholics differ, then the Pope would be to them the final appeal — and what he said would be received. There are other senses in which it is true of the *Church* — viz that she is infallible in greater questions of morals — that is, that she will *always be protected* from all acts seriously infringing on that moral law, which is the inward gift to man as man from God — but the Protestant interpretation of the Archbishop's words is what he did not in his own breast mean — and is therefore a calumny upon him

I am, My dear Madam Sincerely Yours John H Newman

^{^1} In her letter of 2 Oct. Mrs Helbert referred to *Apo.*, pp. 116-17. ^{^1} The High Church party were strongly opposed to the appointment in the autumn of 1869 of Frederick Temple, one of the contributors to *Essays and Reviews*, as Bishop of Exeter. ^{^2} Mrs Helbert asked on 5 Oct., 'if you agree, or will all Catholics be bound to agree in the words of the Archbishop [Manning] respecting the Pope, in his Sermon of yesterday. He makes the Pope say, "I am liberated from all civil subjection my Lord made me the subject of no one on earth . . . and I claim more than this, — I claim to be the Supreme Judge and director of the consciences of men: . . . I am the sole last Supreme Judge of what is right and wrong" —' This was from Manning's sermon on The Syllabus of Errors, delivered at the Pro-Cathedral Kensington on 3 Oct., and reported in *The Times*, (4 Oct.), p. 6.

To Miss M. R. Giberne, The Oratory, 15 October 1870 (Letters and Diaries XXV, p. 215)

15 OCTOBER 1870

TO MISS M. R. GIBERNE

The Oratory October 15. 1870

My dear Sister M. Pia

Of course your life is one of special penance, from the utter dissimilarity between the English and French woman. And it will bring you merit in proportion as it is special and extraordinary. It is impossible that you should help feeling what is humourous, you must

only take care to feel the more love in proportion to the more amusement you have in respect to the objects exciting it.

1 A famous ode of Horace begins 'The just and firm neither civic tumult nor the fierce tyrant shakes etc.'¹

2 Abipones. A people in South America. I think Southey has written about them.²

3 Enceladus was a Titan, who warred against Jupiter.³

4 220 *pro hac vice*. 'In a particular instance, actually occurring at present.'⁴

5. An enthymem is a syllogism with one of its three propositions omitted.⁵

Syllogism. Barbarians are always cruel

The King of Comossee is a barbarian

Therefore — The King of Comossee is cruel.

Enthymeme — The King of Comossee is cruel, because
He is a barbarian.

6. *Securus judicat orbis terrarum* means 'The Christian world judges with security' — that is, 'when all Christians agree together in a judgment, that is a sure warrant that its judgment is right.—'⁶ In consequence, it need not go back, to Scripture, or antiquity, in proof of a point in dispute, if it is in all its members of one way of judging. This saying of St Augustine's is in the teeth of the Anglican maxim, 'Nothing is true but what is to be found in the Antenicene church.'

Give my respects to your Reverend Mother and say that I will not forget her request.

Ever Yours affectly John H Newman

Some nuns are bringing the flannels, we are told.

¹ *Odes* III, iii, 1. *G.A.* p. 37.

² *G.A.* p. 180.

³ *G.A.* p. 198.

⁴ *G.A.* p. 227.

⁵ *G.A.* p. 263.

⁶ *Apo.* p. 116.